

Look at the images. What is John's problem?



Match **each image** with one of the **overwork concepts** and then match them with **explanations**.

- Have you experienced any of these ways companies make us overwork? What other ways do you know?

Overwork Concept:

- | | |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| ✦ Competitive Presenteeism | ✦ Meeting Bloat |
| ✦ Scope Creep | ✦ The "Lunch at the Desk" Norm |
| ✦ Always-On Digital Tether | ✦ Manufactured Urgency |
| ✦ Professional Development Homework | |

Explanations:

- A) John must spend his weekend doing company training.
- B) The team culture forces John to work while he eats.
- C) John stays late just to avoid being the first to leave.
- D) New tasks are added to his workload without a promotion.
- E) A non-critical assignment is labeled urgent for no reason.
- F) Late-night work messages from his boss ruin John's sleep.
- G) His entire day is booked with constant back-to-back meetings.

Here are 3 more ways companies use to make their employees overwork:

- 1. **Gamified Productivity:** Using public leaderboards or tracking software to show how many "tickets" or "tasks" everyone has closed. It turns the office into a race where the "slowest" person (who might just be thorough) feels job insecurity.
- 2. **The "Lean" Team:** Keeping a team intentionally small so that everyone has to do the work of 1.5 people just to keep the department from collapsing. It's framed as being "agile," but it's actually just systemic overwork.
- 3. **The "Family" Narrative:** When a company says, "We're like a family here," it's often code for "We expect you to do us favors (unpaid labor) because of our personal bond." It makes saying "no" feel like a personal betrayal.

Listen to 3 speakers and identify which way each person is talking about. How do they feel about it?



THE ADJECTIVE RULE: FEELING VS. CAUSE

-ED ENDINGS (FEELINGS)

EXHAUSTED
FRUSTRATED
BORED

I am so SCARED!

Human Battery
CHARGED.

Describes how a person feels (Internal Emotion).

-ING ENDINGS (CAUSE)

EXCITING
ANNOYING
HUMILIATING

The movie is SCARING!

Charger
CAUSING.

Describes characteristic of a person, thing, or situation (The Cause of the feeling).

PRO TIP FOR STUDENTS

Think of people as batteries.
-ED = CHARGED with emotion.
The situation is the CHARGER.
-ING = GIVING emotion.

Complete the sentences using the correct form of the word in brackets.

- 1. To be honest, I'm totally _____ (exhaust).
 - 2. If I say I'm busy, my boss looks _____ (disappoint).
 - 3. My manager said it was an _____ (excite) opportunity for me to step up.
 - 4. I'm so _____ (frustrate) because I want to do a good job.
 - 5. At first, it sounded _____ (charm), but now it's just _____ (annoy).
 - 6. I'm _____ (bore) of the guilt trips.
 - 7. I find the whole narrative _____ (insult).
 - 8. It's supposed to be _____ (inspire), but it's just _____ (humiliate).
 - 9. I feel _____ (threaten) and _____ (worry) about my job security every single day.
 - 10. It's an _____ (irritate) way to work.
- What is one specific work task you feel most **bored** with, and what makes it so **tiring**?
 - Have you ever worked for a company that described itself as a "family"? Did you find that narrative **charming** or **annoying**?
 - When you have an **overwhelming** amount of work, do you feel **motivated** to work harder, or do you just feel **stressed**?
 - Do you think it is **inspiring** to work in a high-pressure, "lean" team, or is it just **depressing**?
 - What is the most **disgusting** example of "systemic overwork" you have ever seen?



The Culture of Overwork: Before watching the video, let's learn some key vocabulary.

- 1. If an employee's career is "**derailed**", what has happened?
A) It has become faster and more successful.
B) It has been stopped or slowed down unexpectedly.
C) It has stayed exactly the same for many years.
- 2. What does it mean to be at a client's "**beck and call**"?
A) To be in a balanced professional partnership.
B) To ignore a client's requests until Monday morning.
C) To be always ready to obey or help them immediately.
- 3. The speaker describes a "**pithy**" way to describe the problem.
A) A very long and detailed explanation.
B) A rude or aggressive comment.
C) A brief, clever, and meaningful expression.
- 4. If constant overwork is "**undermining**" a firm, what is it doing?
A) Making the company more famous and popular.
B) Supporting the company's foundations.
C) Gradually making the company weaker or less effective.
- 5. What is "**structural inequality**" in a company?
A) When the office building is of very poor quality.
B) Unfairness that is built into the systems, policies, and culture.
C) When employees have different job titles and salaries.
- 6. What does it mean to "**go against the grain**"?
A) To follow the company rules perfectly.
B) To work in the agriculture or farming industry.
C) To do something different from what is normal or expected.

Discuss the statements. Do you think they are true or false? (Watch the video to check your answers.)

- 1. Modern office cultures often force a difficult choice between career and home.
- 2. Using work-family accommodations is a proven way to accelerate a career path.
- 3. Women fail to advance because they lack the professional ambition of men.
- 4. Both men and women desire a healthy balance between their work and life.
- 5. High-level clients strictly demand that consultants be at their beck and call.
- 6. Massive 100-slide decks are essential for maintaining a firm's market edge.
- 7. Overwork serves as a way for competitive people to appear as superstars.
- 8. A culture of relentless overwork is a highly effective way to increase success.



@Kotori32 In my country (Denmark), working longer hours isn't seen as a sign of dedication. It's seen as a sign of inefficiency, that you can't get your work done inside working hours.

@vividdaydream1516 This video points out the main issue that so many videos talking about lower fertility/birthrates fail to cover: the current work culture of "a job or family life, pick which one you want to keep" effectively bans most employees from having kids.

@mira10045 The reason why AI and robots must replace most human workforce. Let human should work what only human can do.

@kyliemack1131 Boss just announced 50 hours a week for the entire month....idk how im gonna get through this.

@d_hedgehog2970 Objectively speaking it doesn't hurt everyone...Owners and CEOs of the company benefit masively from it.

@Durpy_Man My lads, im so burnt out. Sometimes I'm on the clock for over 14 hours in one day and im only 16. Thats my daily life along with highschool AND collage classes.